

Repositioning McDonald's Burgers as a Healthy Choice



Team 13B

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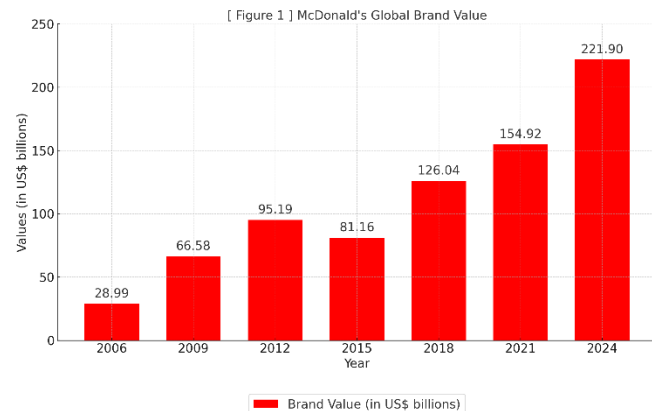
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Table of Contents

I.	Introduction	1
1.	Introduction	1
2.	Challenge and Importance of Repositioning	2
3.	Project Aim.....	3
II.	Situation Analysis	4
1.	PESTLE Analysis	4
2.	Challenge Statement	6
3.	SWOT Analysis	6
III.	Identification of Possible Solutions	7
1.	Highlight Customization to Enhance Health-Oriented Options	8
2.	Health-Oriented Brand Value Campaigns	8
3.	Integrating McDonald's Rewards Program with Health-Focused Products	10
IV.	Evaluation and Choice of Solution.....	10
1.	Highlight Customization to Enhance Health-Oriented Options	10
2.	Health-Oriented Brand Value Campaigns	11
3.	Integrating McDonald's Rewards Program with Health-Focused Products	12
4.	Overview of Solutions	13
5.	The Case for Customization and Health-Oriented Items	13
V.	Outline of Action Plan to Implement a Solution	14
1.	Pilot Testing (3-6 Months)	14
2.	Customer Feedback Integration (Months 6-9)	15
3.	Nationwide Rollout (Months 9-18)	16
4.	Resource and Responsibilities	16
VI.	Conclusion	17
VII.	Reference	19

Introduction:

McDonald's has been a pivotal player in the fast-food sector for over six decades, and it is recognized for its competitive pricing, rapid service, and internationally recognizable Golden Arches. The brand's prominence is fundamentally tied to its ability to deliver convenience and value consistently across a diverse, global consumer base. Through an extensive franchise network and a menu optimized for mass appeal, McDonald's has cemented its status as a household name and a symbol of accessible dining. These foundational attributes have reinforced its leadership position in the fast-food arena, enabling adaptability in varied economic and cultural contexts (Singireddy, 2020).



The fast-food landscape is transforming significantly, propelled by shifting consumer expectations and sociocultural trends. Increasing consumer health awareness reshapes market dynamics as contemporary diners prioritize nutrition, wellness, and sustainability. This shift is especially prominent among the younger generations, consumers who exhibit heightened awareness regarding their dietary selections and demand elevated standards in transparency, ethical sourcing, and corporate social responsibility (Frozenet, n.d.). These segments actively seek healthier meal offerings that align with their values, creating an urgent imperative for brands to evolve with these preferences.

In light of the rising demand for healthier alternatives, numerous competitors in the fast-food industry are strategically positioning themselves to cater to health-conscious consumers. Through menus emphasizing lower calorie counts and using organic and sustainably sourced ingredients, established entities and new entrants are redefining the parameters of fast food (Helal, 2023). The emergence of plant-based substitutes, enhanced transparency around nutritional metrics, and commitments towards sustainability are intensifying competition, altering industry dynamics, and pushing the envelope on innovation.

Against this backdrop, McDonald's faces a dual challenge: adapting its brand image to attract health-focused consumers while preserving the core attributes that have established it as a global icon. This challenge requires a thorough strategic shift, focusing on transforming public perception and strengthening its dedication to transparency, sustainability, and ethical standards. McDonald's must navigate a delicate balance between embedding health-oriented principles and sustaining the convenience, affordability, and familiarity that have traditionally been its strengths.

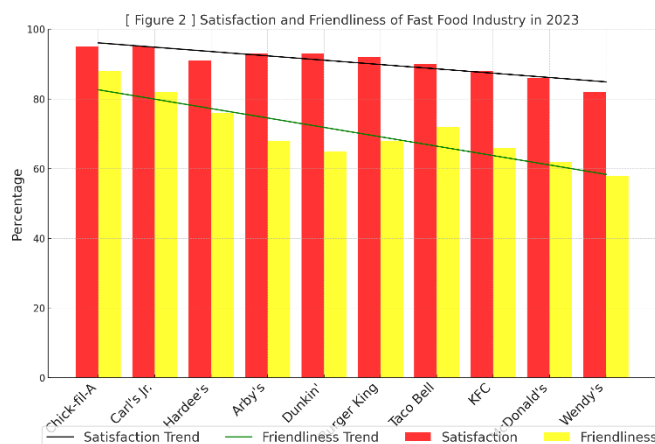
To maintain its market leadership, McDonald's must meticulously navigate this transition, ensuring alignment with contemporary consumer expectations without alienating its established customer base. This peculiar balance necessitates a holistic approach that emphasizes refining

brand positioning, revamping marketing strategies, and strengthening commitments to ethical and sustainable operational practices. Successfully navigating this transitional phase will allow McDonald's to maintain its relevance in an increasingly competitive and health-conscious marketplace, securing its status as a brand that resonates with a diverse and evolving global audience.

As the fast-food sector progresses, McDonald's capacity for innovation and adaptation will be crucial in shaping its future trajectory. By embedding health-conscious values into its brand identity while preserving the attributes that have positioned it as an industry leader, McDonald's can propel the next chapter of its legacy and maintain its status as a fundamental pillar within the fast-food landscape.

Challenge and Importance of Repositioning:

The fast-food industry is undergoing a notable transformation driven by an increasing focus on health and evolving consumer preferences. For McDonald's, a pivotal marketing challenge lies in redefining its iconic core offering, which consists of quality food and speed of service, to cater to the demands of health-conscious consumers while preserving its foundational brand identity. Traditionally, McDonald's has been associated with convenience, affordability, and reliability, enabling it to capture a diverse global audience. However, with young generations emphasizing healthier, sustainable, and ethically transparent food options, McDonald's need to adapt has become evident (Jha et al., 2022).



This rebranding effort entails navigating a complex array of challenges. On the one hand, McDonald's must refine its brand identity to resonate with the value of health-conscious consumers, highlighting its commitment to modern nutritional standards and ethical consumption trends. On the other hand, it must ensure that these adjustments do not alienate its existing customer base, which values the brand for its quick-service model, cost-effectiveness, and familiarity. Achieving this equilibrium demands a strategic framework that harmonizes health-conscious innovation with the core attributes that have historically made McDonald's appealing.

The complexity of this endeavor is intensified by a competitive landscape in which both established and emerging players are vying for the health-focused consumer segment. Competitors such as Chipotle and Subway are effectively introducing low-calorie, sustainably sourced offerings while adeptly communicating their alignment with health trends (Hoffman, 2014). Competitors' focus exhibits how they strategically position themselves in the market for health-focused

consumers. For McDonald's, a successful path forward involves leveraging its extensive global footprint and robust brand equity to innovate to meet consumer expectations and underscore its legacy of quality, affordability, and convenience.

The repositioning of McDonald's flagship identity calls for a strategy emphasizing brand messaging refinement and targeted marketing initiatives while maintaining its core values. These initiatives should effectively communicate McDonald's commitment to health-focused values while retaining accessibility and budget-friendliness. By undertaking this multifaceted approach, McDonald's can redefine its relevance in a rapidly evolving industry landscape (Xue et al., 2018).

Project Aim:

This report intends to pinpoint strategic avenues for McDonald's to successfully realign its burgers and culture to cater to the preferences of health-focused consumers. The objective is to deliver practical insights and strategies that enable McDonald's to adjust its brand image, align with health-driven trends, and reinforce its reputation as an innovative leader within the fast-food sector.

It is essential to perform market analysis to assess the successful tactics employed by competitors who have embraced health trends and adapted their offerings accordingly. By analyzing these strategies, we can glean valuable lessons and identify potential best practices that McDonald's might adopt to remain competitive in a health-conscious market.

Furthermore, an assessment of strategic approaches will explore innovative ways McDonald's can align its brand positioning with the preferences of health-conscious consumers. To preserve the brand's standing for affordability and the convenience that fast food is known for its primary focus will be on conveying its dedication to sustainability and wellness.

Enhancing brand strategy will be accomplished by exploring strategies to reshape consumer perceptions of McDonald's, aiming to establish it as a brand championing wellness and sustainability. Improving brand strategy includes communicating the company's commitment to healthy eating and sustainable practices while maintaining the brand's iconic identity and essence that loyal customers have come to love.

This report will comprehensively analyze consumer behavior, market dynamics, and industry standards to propose a well-rounded repositioning strategy. The recommendations will focus on achieving a balanced integration of tradition and innovation, allowing McDonald's to preserve its reliability for loyal customers while appealing to an increasing number of health-conscious diners.

By effectively addressing this challenge, McDonald's can reinforce its position as a market leader, adapt to changing consumer preferences, and sustain its relevance in an increasingly centered health and wellness industry.

Situation Analysis:

The increasing health consciousness among consumers catalyzes a significant transformation within the fast-food industry. Foodinsight states, “Three in four consumers say food consumption impacts their mental or emotional well-being in 2023.” Research indicates that a substantial segment of fast-food customers now prioritizes nutritional content when making dining choices. This shift toward healthier

options reflects broader societal wellness, sustainability, and transparency trends. Notable convenience food brands such as Chipotle and Subway have capitalized on this market demand by promoting menus that align with these values, demonstrating that a health-oriented positioning can enhance customer loyalty and facilitate growth (Ariffin & Mohsin, 2021).

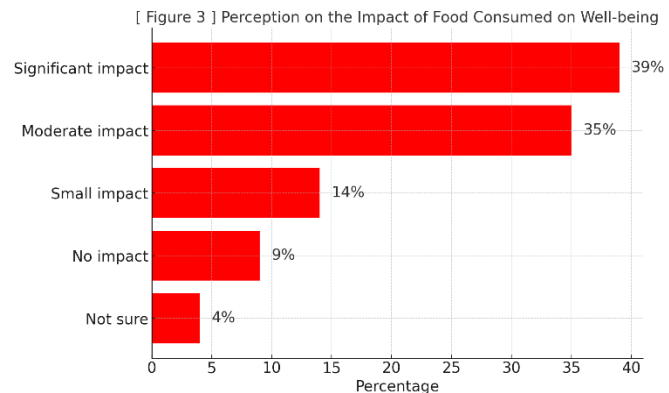
The emphasis on sustainable consumption by young generations markedly influences their dietary preferences. These cohorts value customization highly, seeking individualized meal options that address specific nutritional needs while adhering to their environmentally conscious principles. For example, offerings such as plant-based meats and low-carbohydrate substitutes are attractive to these demographics, who frequently pursue dietary patterns such as ketogenic or veganism (Folkvord et al., 2020). Furthermore, transparency regarding sources and nutritional information is critical for health-centric fast-food strategies, as it fosters greater brand trust.

As established companies like Wendy’s and Burger King introduce healthier menu items, such as plant-based salads and burgers, competition within the industry has become increasingly intense (OSUM, n.d.). Nonetheless, McDonald’s retains the opportunity to assume a leadership role by adopting a robust and distinctive health-focused positioning, as many of its competitors have yet to fully capitalize on their products’ health potential. By leveraging its extensive global presence and strong brand recognition, McDonald’s can redefine its relevance by strategically integrating health-conscious values into its brand identity and communication efforts. This strategy should include an expanded definition of health that encompasses nutrition and sustainability, an area in which McDonald’s has already initiated progress through commitments to eco-friendly packaging and sourcing (Knox, 2004). This approach aligns with evolving consumer expectations and reinforces McDonald’s position as a leader in a rapidly changing industry.

PESTLE Analysis:

The PESTLE analysis of McDonald’s provides a comprehensive overview of the critical external factors affecting the company's operations and strategic decisions across various domains.

The increasing government regulations on food safety, labeling, and public health initiatives significantly influence the fast-food landscape. These regulations give McDonald’s



unique opportunities to demonstrate its commitment to transparency and healthier food offerings. As local governments adopt measures like sugar and soda taxes, McDonald's can demonstrate its commitment to public health by aligning its brand messaging with this initiative. This strategy helps attract a growing demographic of health-conscious consumers. It enhances the brand's reputation through collaborations on community health initiatives, such as partnerships with local health organizations and participation in public health campaigns.

The demand for fast food is highly correlated with economic conditions and evolving consumer preferences. During economic downturns, consumers prioritize affordability; therefore, McDonald's must offer value-oriented options. Conversely, when disposable incomes rise, there is a noticeable shift in consumer behavior toward seeking premium, healthier choices. To navigate these shifting demands, McDonald's can leverage its strong brand identity and strategic adaptability to position itself as a reliable choice for diverse consumer needs, including affordable meals and higher-grade, health-focused options. This strategic diversity allows the company to effectively address the operational challenges associated with fluctuating commodity prices and changing consumer tastes. Additionally, technological advancements in digital payment solutions and e-commerce platforms can enhance customer convenience, boosting brand loyalty.

The preferences of younger generations are rapidly evolving. These consumers are increasingly health-conscious and demand more transparency, customization, and unique dining experiences. For McDonald's, this means repositioning its brand to cater to these preferences and engaging younger customers through innovative and immersive dining experiences. Potential solutions could include pop-up events, community involvement initiatives, and interactive promotions that resonate with diverse consumer groups. Moreover, the role of social media cannot be underestimated; McDonald's must maintain consistent communication of its values, sustainability efforts, and product offerings across all platforms, ensuring engagement and trust among its audience.

The ongoing technological advancements present numerous opportunities for McDonald's to enhance customer experience and operational efficiency. Implementing AI-driven solutions, such as personalized recommendations based on individual dietary preferences and order history, can significantly streamline the decision-making process for health-focused consumers. Furthermore, a user-friendly mobile application that provides transparent nutritional information allows for customized meal options and facilitates easy ordering can reinforce McDonald's commitment to meeting the needs of its health-conscious customer base. Adopting such technologies elevates the customer experience and aligns with the growing trend of digital engagement in the fast-food industry.

Strict adherence to international food safety standards is vital in the fast-food sector, as non-compliance can lead to severe legal repercussions and loss of consumer trust. Ensuring that marketing claims about health benefits and nutritional information are accurate and truthful is crucial. By proactively updating its packaging and ingredient listings to comply with nutritional disclosure regulations, McDonald's can further solidify its reputation for transparency and reliability among consumers. Regular audits and compliance checks can also help mitigate.

The increasing consumer focus on sustainability demands McDonald's reassess its environmental practices, which include adopting eco-friendly initiatives in food production, packaging, and waste management. Strategies such as sourcing sustainable ingredients, minimizing single-use plastics, and optimizing supply chain processes to reduce carbon footprints can significantly enhance the company's brand image.

By aligning its business strategies with these PESTLE insights, McDonald's can improve its position in the competitive fast-food market and respond effectively to consumers' evolving expectations and regulatory pressures regarding sustainability and environmental responsibility. This proactive approach will be essential in building long-term resilience and relevance in an ever-changing market landscape.

Challenge Statements:

The primary challenge for McDonald's is to balance repositioning its brand to appeal to health-conscious consumers and preserving its core identity as a quick and affordable dining option. Achieving this goal requires McDonald's to reshape its brand perception without alienating its existing customer base.

The repositioning efforts should focus on communicating McDonald's commitment to health-conscious values while continuing to highlight its convenience and affordability. Effective communication is essential for bridging the gap between health-focused innovations and the brand's traditional identity. McDonald's must demonstrate its commitment to healthier choices while reassuring its loyal customers and redefining its brand to meet evolving consumer demands without losing its fundamental appeal.

SWOT Analysis:

McDonald's strengths lie in its highly efficient supply chain, extensive global presence, and exceptional brand recognition, allowing the company to adapt swiftly to market trends while benefiting from economies of scale to offer competitive prices. The brand maintains consistent quality and customer experience across different markets through its global standardization processes and franchise model, which also support rapid expansion and local adaptation. Moreover, McDonald's leverages customer data from digital platforms to promote healthier menu options and tailor marketing efforts, while partnerships with suppliers enable the incorporation of sustainably sourced ingredients. This global footprint permits McDonald's to pilot health-conscious innovations in specific regions before broader implementation, minimizing resource waste and costs.

However, McDonald's faces challenges rooted in its reputation as a traditional fast-food chain, often associated with high-calorie, less nutritious offerings. This perception complicates its ambition to reposition itself as a health-conscious brand, necessitating a change in consumer mindset and brand communication. Although healthier menu items have been introduced, regional inconsistencies in product availability may hinder successful repositioning. The company's

commitment to value pricing further complicates the introduction of premium health-oriented offerings, as consumers may perceive these items as too costly. Achieving a coherent message and consistent strategy across markets is critical to overcoming these hurdles.

On the opportunity front, technological advancements offer McDonald's a chance to innovate its offerings and enhance customer experiences. The increasing consumer preference for sustainable and nutritious options puts McDonald's in a favorable position to lead in this evolving market by blending health and sustainability into its brand identity. Initiatives such as expanding plant-based menu options, sustainable packaging, and carbon-neutral goals can further establish McDonald's as a modern and responsible brand. By promoting the nutritional benefits of existing items and implementing transparent labeling, McDonald's can attract health-conscious consumers. Collaborations with health-focused organizations or influencers may reshape public perception and strengthen repositioning efforts, while sustainability initiatives can enhance their appeal to environmentally conscious customers.

Nonetheless, McDonald's faces significant threats in an increasingly competitive fast-food landscape. Established competitors focus on health-conscious offerings, while niche brands specializing in organic, vegan, or allergen-friendly foods attract health-focused consumers. As demand for transparency and wellness grows, McDonald's must proactively adapt to maintain market share against more agile rivals. Economic downturns also pose challenges, as consumers might prioritize cost over wellness, complicating the balance between premium health products and affordability. Finally, negative publicity regarding ingredient sourcing or environmental practices could threaten the company's sustainability and health ambitions. McDonald's must consider countless factors to reposition a brand's place in the market.

Identification of Possible Solutions:

Repositioning McDonald's as a health-conscious brand necessitates strategies that uphold its core values of affordability and convenience while catering to changing consumer preferences and market demands. A multitude of possible solutions can propel McDonald's into the industry leader. Focusing on customization and highlighting health-centric menu options can allow McDonald's to shift its brand strategy and minimize resource expenditure. This strategy aims to incorporate flexibility, quality, and transparency into McDonald's offerings to align with modern trends.

In addition to the customization and highlighting of existing health options, there is also an opportunity for McDonald's to go outward with health marketing to solidify its newly repositioned brand image. The concept that McDonald's needs to market externally is a focus on people-centered health based on its original brand story (Owolabi, 2013). Specific programs include a combination of online and offline health-oriented brand value campaigns and the integration of McDonald's rewards program into its health products.

Solution 1: Highlight Customization to Enhance Health-Oriented Options

Customization allows customers to tailor their meals according to their dietary needs and preferences, thus appealing to a broader audience. McDonald's can attract health-conscious consumers, including those seeking plant-based alternatives, by repackaging their burgers in a marketable way towards health. For example, utilizing their already preset customization options on the McDonald's app allows users to feel empowered while marketing their products differently. This can include different styles of low-carb items, lettuce wrapped, keto, and other healthy hot words. Customers can modify their orders by removing buns and opting for lettuce wraps, effectively creating "protein-style" burgers that align with low-carb and ketogenic diets. For instance, ordering a Big Mac without the bun results in a meal with approximately 5 grams of net carbs, 27 grams of fat, and 18 grams of protein (Hip2Keto, n.d.). Various protein options, such as chicken, turkey, beef, and plant-based patties, will allow the company to highlight high-protein options. This approach can seamlessly integrate into existing digital platforms and menus, enabling customers to substitute ingredients or enhance their meals while providing real-time calorie and nutritional information. Marketing campaigns can emphasize customization with slogans like "Your Burger, Your Way," "Keto-Friendly," and "Macro-Friendly," which cater to the target audience. showcasing diverse customer scenarios demonstrating McDonald's commitment to personalized dining experiences.

Furthermore, highlighting current health-centric menu options by creating a dedicated section for nutritious offerings. This menu could feature items like grilled chicken burgers, vegan patties, and salads, all clearly labeled with their calorie counts and nutritional benefits. To optimize visibility, these health-focused items should be prominently displayed across menus and digital platforms, supported by trained staff who can promote these options effectively. Positioning these choices as an integral part of McDonald's menu reinforces the brand's commitment to wellness and transparency, further solidifying trust and loyalty, especially among younger consumers who prioritize informed eating practices.

Solution 2: Health-Oriented Brand Value Campaigns

First, McDonald's needs to identify how they are going to continue a new healthy story in conjunction with their past brand story (Lucarelli & Coolsen, 2023). McDonald's mission is to 'Make delicious feel-good moments easy for everyone,' so the proposed repositioning ideas will start with 'people'. From a supply chain perspective, McDonald's should consider establishing direct relationships with suppliers and farmers to ensure that the quality and origin of the ingredients used meet health standards. For example, the use of pesticide-free vegetables, hormone-free meats, and non-GMO ingredients could be used to enhance the health attributes of the product in this way and highlight this collaboration in marketing. According to the information asymmetry theory, in the marketplace, consumers usually lack sufficient information to make decisions, and providing transparent information can reduce this asymmetry and enhance

consumer trust. By enhancing product transparency in its marketing campaigns, McDonald's is able to provide consumers with a clear understanding of the ingredients, nutritional information, and preparation process of its products, which not only removes customers' doubts about the authenticity of healthy options but also builds the brand's credibility (Han & Ham, 2019). McDonald's repositioning entry point of transparency emphasizes healthy ingredients in a way that is consistent with their brand mission of making customers happy (Choi & Reid, 2018).

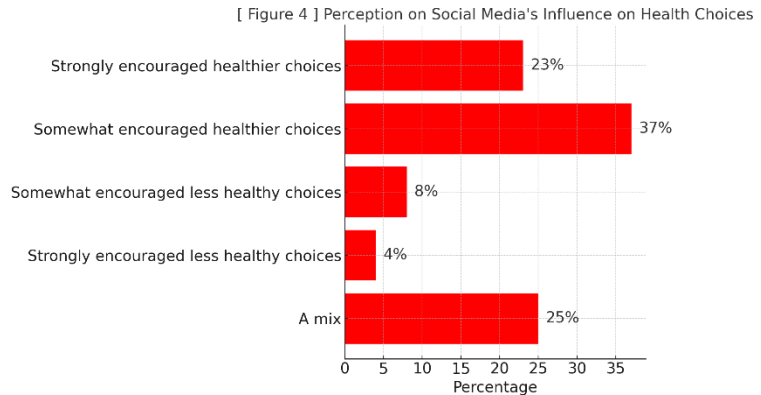
To effectively promote its health concept, McDonald's should harness the power of social media by collaborating with three key groups: celebrities, professionals, and influencers. Engaging platforms like Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube fit perfectly with the Diffusion of Innovations Theory (Rangaswamy et al., 2020), allowing McDonald's to reach a broad audience with its new health messaging.

McDonald's can strengthen its communication of the new brand identity through impactful celebrity endorsements (Quesenberry & Coolsen, 2023). This strategy leverages the Brand Personality Theory, where the innate social influence and relatable qualities of celebrities can rapidly amplify McDonald's new concept, helping to create strong recognition and favorable feelings toward the brand in the marketplace (Kim et al., 2001). Given that Generation Z consumers often connect emotionally with their favorite celebrities, this approach is likely to increase their positive perception of McDonald's and encourage them to try its healthier product offerings (Lina et al., 2022).

Collaborating with professionals such as dietitians, athletes, renowned chefs, and fitness trainers on social media is another powerful strategy. This is underpinned by Social Identity Theory, which demonstrates that endorsements from credible figures in their fields can significantly enhance consumer trust in the quality and healthfulness of McDonald's products (Farivar & Wang, 2022).

Engaging with influencers can provide insights into the everyday lives of consumers. These content creators are adept at capturing attention and driving engagement through relatable and compelling material. Partnering with them can yield innovative and exciting content—think videos, blogs, and social media posts—that not only spark interest but also encourage deeper interactions with the brand (Leung et al., 2022). According to Content Marketing Theory, valuable and engaging content is crucial for effective brand communication and fostering customer loyalty, ultimately solidifying McDonald's redefined image in the market (Rancati & Gordini, 2014).

For offline strategies, McDonald's should focus on co-branding, sponsorships, and interactive pop-up events. By partnering with brands that emphasize health and sustainability—



like organic and eco-friendly companies—McDonald’s can showcase its commitment to healthy ingredients and responsible practices (Pinello et al., 2022). This cooperative marketing approach not only enhances McDonald’s reputation but also reinforces its healthy positioning in consumers’ minds. Sponsorships also present an opportunity for McDonald’s to revitalize its brand image. By aligning with health-related initiatives and sports events, the brand can engage directly with its audience. Moreover, establishing pop-up locations in high-traffic areas to promote health-themed meals can intrigue consumers. Offering themed gifts or incentives can stimulate interest and create memorable interactions that strengthen brand perceptions (Cornwell & Kwon, 2022).

Solution 3: Integrating McDonald's Rewards Program with Health-Focused Products

Beyond digital and in-person marketing, McDonald’s can enrich its rewards system to encourage healthier eating. By clearly labeling “healthy menu options” in the app and store menus—with categories like low-calorie, sugar-free, and high-protein selections—customers can easily make informed choices. Offering additional points for purchasing healthier items taps into the Incentive Theory, which posits that rewards motivate consumers to focus on healthy eating and align with McDonald’s commitment to promoting nutritious options (Gallus et al., 2022). Not only will this increase customer engagement, but it can decrease the number of health-focused consumers spending their money with competitors.

Furthermore, the direct incentive of reward points enhances the attractiveness of healthy choices by rewarding consumers for their healthy selections. By providing exclusive discounts or bonus points for repeat purchases of health-oriented meals, McDonald’s can cultivate brand loyalty among its customers and gain market share among their competitors. This mirrors the Customer Loyalty Theory, which indicates that consistent rewards and offers bolster customer allegiance to a brand. By launching a long-term rewards program, McDonald’s stands to not only promote healthier eating habits but also dramatically increase customer retention and loyalty.

Evaluation and Choice of Solution:

Solution 1: Customization to Enhance Health-Oriented Options

Customization and restructuring current options allow customers to personalize their meals based on their dietary preferences and needs. Customers can choose from a variety of proteins, such as chicken, turkey, beef, and plant-based patties. They can also swap ingredients, like choosing lettuce wraps or adding more vegetables. This feature will be part of McDonald’s digital platforms and menus, providing real-time nutritional information. This helps customers make informed and healthy choices and helps McDonald’s gain market share from their competitors.

In Solution 1, the projected financial performance offers a compelling examination of the advantages of customization as a strategic initiative for McDonald’s to effectively cater to health-conscious consumers. By anticipating approximately 75,000 additional orders, with each order

averaging an expenditure of \$13, McDonald's stands to generate an incremental revenue estimated at an impressive \$975,000. When one accounts for the marketing expenditures, which are forecasted at \$300,000, in addition to product costs amounting to \$7 per item—culminating in a total product cost of \$525,000—the overall costs culminate at \$825,000. This careful financial analysis reveals a net profit of \$150,000, translating into a noteworthy return on investment (ROI) of 18%. Although the total number of products sold during the rollout phase is not extreme, the low cost of upkeep and implementation of this solution provides a high return on investment. These calculations highlight a judicious balance between driving revenue growth and managing costs prudently, establishing customization as a compelling and cost-effective strategy for enhancing McDonald's health-oriented product offerings.

A major benefit of this approach is that it is cost-effective, requiring few changes to operations or product development. By making these offerings more visible, McDonald's can attract health-conscious customers who may not know about these options. Additionally, providing clear nutritional information builds trust and meets consumers' demand for transparency.

The main strength of this approach is its appeal to many people, especially those with specific diets like vegetarian, keto, and high protein. By using technology, this solution meets the expectations of modern consumers who want convenience and transparency. Slogan campaigns will improve McDonald's image as a customer-focused brand. Moreover, the data collected from customer choices can help develop future menus and targeted marketing strategies.

Customization, in conjunction with marketing existing healthy options, can avoid challenges for operations and high costs and allow McDonald's to maintain its focus on the usual products that drive the business. McDonald's will not need to adjust kitchen workflows, change inventory procedures, or train staff extensively to handle these options. This allows McDonald's to limit costs and focus on marketing strategies to ultimately reposition itself as the leader in health-oriented options in the market.

Solution 2: Health-Oriented Brand Value Campaigns

This solution aims to improve how people view McDonald's through targeted marketing. The plan will use social media platforms like Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube to partner with celebrities, influencers, and professionals such as dietitians, athletes, and chefs. Additionally, McDonald's will team up with health-focused companies and sponsor wellness events to show its commitment to healthy values.

Solution 2 illuminates the substantial impact of forming strategic partnerships to elevate McDonald's health-focused branding campaigns. With projections indicating around 200,000 orders at an average spend of \$18 per order, the anticipated incremental revenue soars to \$3,600,000. However, this campaign necessitates significant marketing costs totaling approximately \$2,000,000 to effectively establish and nurture the desired partnerships, at \$200,000 for 10 partner sponsorships. In addition, product costs are calculated at \$7 per item—amounting to \$1,400,000. Therefore, the total costs aggregate to \$3,400,000, which leads to a net profit of

\$200,000 and an ROI of 6%. While this ROI appears comparatively lower than those associated with other strategic solutions, this approach possesses the potential to significantly enhance McDonald's brand equity and cultivate enduring consumer trust. By positioning the company as a leader in health-focused offerings through brand sponsorships, it can establish a stronger connection with its target market.

One of the strengths of this strategy is its potential to enhance brand perception, especially among younger audiences who pay attention to social media and endorsements from trusted figures. Co-branding and sponsorships can highlight McDonald's dedication to health and sustainability. Also, hosting engaging health-themed pop-up events can connect with customers on a personal level.

This approach mainly addresses external perceptions without making real changes to the menu. Without genuine improvements to products and operations, McDonald's risks being seen as simply promoting healthier options without substance. The success of this strategy depends on careful implementation, choosing the right influencers, and creating honest messages. The company must allocate large amounts of resources to fund the advertising campaigns. While this plan is useful for increasing customer engagement and changing perceptions, it must be combined with real changes to products and services for lasting impact in the competitive landscape.

Solution 3: Integrating McDonald's Rewards Program with Health-Focused Products

The idea of McDonald's rewards system to promote healthier eating offers significant opportunities for consumer engagement and brand loyalty. By offering incentives such as additional reward points for healthier purchases, McDonald's can align with an audience well-versed in applications and appeal to an audience increasingly focused on wellness. This strategy leverages psychological tactics to drive behavior change, making healthier eating more rewarding and accessible.

Solution 3 focuses on integrating a rewards program into McDonald's health-oriented products. With an expected 150,000 orders averaging \$15 each, the projected incremental revenue is \$2,250,000. The initiative requires \$100,000 for marketing and \$1,050,000 for product costs, totaling \$2,050,000. This results in a net profit of \$200,000 and an ROI of 10%. While the ROI is modest, the strategy emphasizes long-term customer engagement and brand loyalty, potentially increasing profitability through repeat purchases.

It can also differentiate McDonald's from competitors who may not prioritize health-conscious incentives, helping to capture a larger share of health-focused consumers. Customer engagement will rise as users will likely interact with McDonald's app more frequently to track points, explore menus, and take advantage of offers. Such actions not only enhance the customer experience but also provide McDonald's with valuable data for personalized marketing and product development.

However, this approach is not without potential downsides. There is not only a high cost of integration of this rewards system but there is also a large cost associated with continuous upkeep. Implementing and maintaining a robust rewards system with meaningful incentives could involve high operational and technological costs. This strategy could even backfire by creating the perception that McDonald's is pivoting away from its core identity of affordability and indulgence. While the rewards system could promote healthier choices, McDonald's must strike a balance to ensure it does not alienate its existing customer base while embracing a more health-conscious audience.

Overview of Solutions:

McDonald's has several strategies to consider that align with health-conscious trends while maintaining its market leadership. Highlighting customization and existing health options stands out as the most transformative option, effectively catering to consumer preferences for personalized dining while upholding the brand's strengths of convenience and affordability. This solution also offers the highest ROI due to the low cost of implementation, even though additional orders do not increase as much as other options.

On the other hand, health-oriented brand campaigns can reshape perceptions but must be accompanied by real product changes to avoid being perceived as superficial. Integrating rewards programs can foster customer loyalty and support health initiatives, but their impact is maximized when part of a broader strategy. In summary, while customization offers a sustainable path forward, complementary approaches like branding campaigns and rewards integration can enhance its effectiveness.

The Case for Customization and Health-Oriented Items:

Customization and marketing of existing health options emerge as a highly effective strategy for McDonald's, aligning perfectly with the brand's strengths of convenience, affordability, and widespread appeal while addressing the needs of health-conscious consumers. The strength of this solution is its ease of implementation, low costs, and high possibility of attracting health-conscious consumers to the market. This approach empowers customers by allowing them to personalize their meals according to their dietary preferences, catering to a diverse audience that includes vegetarians, flexitarians, and individuals with specific health goals. Such personalization particularly resonates with health consumers, who prioritize tailored experiences and transparency in their food choices.

The integration of customization is manageable within McDonald's existing digital platforms—like kiosks, apps, and online ordering—enhancing user engagement with features such as ingredient substitutions and real-time nutritional information. Thanks to McDonald's efficient supply chain and operations, they are well-equipped to navigate the complexities this additional offering may introduce, avoiding high costs and resource allocation.

Furthermore, personalization and outlining current health options align with McDonald's core brand identity of providing quick, accessible, and affordable meals, but they aim to expand this consumer base. By offering healthier options through personalized choices, the brand can enhance its appeal without alienating its loyal customer base that values familiarity and convenience. Repackaging and marketing the current items on the menu allow the company to keep costs low, focus on campaigns, and ultimately gain market share from competitors.

From a marketing standpoint, the strategy offers considerable flexibility. Campaigns featuring slogans can highlight the diverse options available, make health foods relatable, and allow McDonald's to constantly adjust to current health trends due to the low-cost nature of altering this strategy. Customization and repackaging current health-oriented items on the menu will position McDonald's as an inclusive and innovative brand that caters to a wide demographic focused on both health and indulgence.

Additionally, customization serves as a key differentiator in a competitive landscape where other brands offer health-focused menus. By enabling consumers to co-create their meals, McDonald's can foster customer loyalty and diminish the threat of competitors.

Lastly, the potential for scalability and innovation is significant; McDonald's can introduce seasonal or regional ingredients, keeping the menu fresh and engaging. The insights gained from customer preferences can further inform product development and targeted marketing efforts, solidifying customization as a forward-thinking strategy for the brand.

Outline of Action Plan to Implement a Solution:

To successfully integrate customization and health-focused menu options, McDonald's must create a meticulously crafted action plan that prioritizes smooth execution and maximizes positive consumer impact. This plan encompasses three pivotal phases: pilot testing, feedback integration, and nationwide rollout.

Pilot Testing (3-6 Months)

The plan begins with pilot testing, where select locations will serve as proving grounds for our innovative strategies. Using in-depth demographic and market research, the company targets high-potential sites that can showcase the benefits of our new menu offerings. Regions highly focused on healthy living, active lifestyles, and health-oriented choices will provide varied data for the testing. Conducting this research in different locations can give the company an insight into which options and types of customizations thrive in certain or all areas. This phase is essential for gathering valuable insights, optimizing processes, and validating our approach.

These locations will feature customizable options and health-focused menu items tailored to meet evolving consumer demands and preferences. The company slogans discussed, along with marketing that repackages current items, will appear as new product lines or options to the consumer, creating a sense of control, health, and individualization in the psyche of the consumer.

The aim is to create an unforgettable dining experience driven by personalization and health-oriented marketing.

To enhance customer experience, the company will highlight cutting-edge digital ordering systems that allow for easy customization, ensuring a seamless interaction from start to finish. Luckily, many of these technologies are already available in every McDonald's. Now, we are using McDonald's stellar resources to recreate the customer experience.

Throughout this phase, marketing and product development teams will lead the introduction of "new" menu features and product campaigns while technology teams ensure the digital enhancements are fully operational. Additionally, store managers and staff will receive specialized training to guarantee that they can efficiently facilitate customer requests. Resources such as extra ingredients, technology upgrades, and promotional materials will be allocated to maximize outreach and engagement. Luckily, any adjustments in the campaign can be pivoted quickly due to its low-cost nature. This phase will be refined within a timeframe of 3 to 6 months, tailoring the approach as necessary.

Customer Feedback Integration (Months 6-9)

Following the pilot phase, it becomes crucial to actively engage with our customers to refine the offerings based on their feedback. Customers are the drivers in this sector, and without their honest feedback, McDonald's would risk losing market share by having consumers go to competitors. We will utilize surveys, focus groups, and social media monitoring to collect rich, actionable insights into customer satisfaction and areas of improvement. Multiple forms of feedback data will be taken to ensure McDonald's creates the most customer-centric campaign, which will ultimately outshine the market.

Next, thoroughly examining sales data will help the company determine the popularity and profitability of the new customizable and health-oriented items. Feedback is one thing, but sales give actual insight into the behavior of consumers at different locations. This will give insight into how the campaign will affect sales, inventory and sentiment along the way. This second phase is instrumental in fine-tuning our menu to better align with consumer expectations.

The customer insights team will take the lead during this phase, coordinating closely with product development to refine recipes and with marketing teams to optimize our messaging strategies. Adjustments and enhancements will be driven by the data collected, along with sales numbers, ensuring our offerings resonate with our customers. Essential resources required during this phase include feedback analysis tools and funding for process revisions, which are already part of the McDonald's warship. Customer feedback during the rollout will allow McDonald's to continuously refine the campaign on customization and health-focused marketing. By the time of nationwide rollout, the campaign will be a well-tested, fine-tuned, data-driven machine.

Nationwide Rollout (Months 9-18)

The final phase involves scaling our successful strategy to every McDonald's location nationwide. This is where we will unleash the full potential of the campaign. Customizing and highlighting existing health options will eventually be at every location and on every application nationwide. After months of pilot testing and customer feedback, the nationwide rollout will be ready to attack health-oriented consumers everywhere. The rollout will introduce customization features and health-focused menu items to all locations, supported by an extensive marketing campaign that highlights these innovative offerings. This campaign will emphasize the benefits of personalization and the health advantages of our new menu—effectively reaching consumers across digital platforms, traditional media, and promotional avenues.

Marketing teams will lead promotional strategies, utilizing marketing tactics, campaign slogans, and promotional avenues to tailor to the target market. Consumers will have no choice but to crown McDonald's, the market leader.

Operational teams will ensure smooth execution across multiple locations and ensure the months of testing and feedback are consistent with inventory demands and employee training. Luckily, the nature of customization and health-oriented highlights will mainly be an inventory change, not an increase in costs. Supply chain teams will adeptly manage the diverse ingredient needs that are already part of the inventory lists.

This nine-month phase allows for a careful rollout, ensuring consistency in quality and customer experience. The company will embark on 9 months of testing and feedback and 9 months of rollout. The 9 months of rollout will allow McDonald's to continuously fine-tune, adjust, and adapt to market demands. There will be a slow path to maintaining current market dominance and slowly chipping away at what will bring consumers over from competitors.

Resources and Responsibilities:

Each phase will require robust collaboration across all departments. The synergy between marketing, technology, product development, operations, and supply chain teams are critical for successfully implementing our strategy. Investments in training and resources are minimal due to the easily integrated nature of the campaign. Paramount to support our offerings and secure their success. The responsibilities of all teams across the company will not have to be overhauled to contribute to this campaign. McDonald's is essentially highlighting already existing features, and repackaging it to the customer to create a new experience.

This action plan is not just a roadmap; it is a vital opportunity for McDonald's to advance its repositioning goals. By skillfully integrating customization with health-focused innovations, we will create a superior customer experience that aligns with modern consumer preferences, paving the way for sustained growth and a competitive edge in the marketplace. Embracing this initiative is not merely a choice; it is a necessary step toward securing our future success.

Conclusion:

McDonald's finds itself at a crucial turning point as it responds to the sweeping changes in the fast-food industry, shaped by an increasing demand for healthier options and innovative competition. For years, McDonald's has been the dominant force in the market, celebrated for its convenience, affordability, and brand familiarity, earning its status as a global icon. However, the evolving priorities of today's consumers, particularly younger audiences, have shifted their focus to nutrition, sustainability, and transparency. This presents a dual challenge for McDonald's: it must satisfy the health-conscious consumer while maintaining the foundational qualities that have endeared it to loyal customers.

To effectively address these challenges, the most promising strategy is to embrace customization and highlight current health options as the cornerstone of McDonald's repositioning efforts. By allowing customers to tailor their meals according to their dietary preferences, McDonald's can address diverse consumer needs, including those adhering to vegetarian, keto, or other specialized diets. This approach not only reflects the brand's strengths of affordability and convenience but also modernizes its menu to align with contemporary consumer expectations. The integration of digital platforms, like kiosks and mobile apps, enhances this strategy by providing real-time nutritional information and fostering greater customer engagement.

Customization and outlining the existing items currently available serve as powerful differentiators in a competitive landscape. While competitors have established themselves as leaders in health-oriented dining, McDonald's has the opportunity to create a unique space by allowing customers to co-create their meals. This interactive dining experience empowers customers and encourages brand loyalty. Marketing initiatives can highlight the inclusivity and personalization this strategy embodies, reinforcing McDonald's position as a contemporary, consumer-driven leader in the fast-food sector.

Although repackaging available options and customization is a key strategy, additional supporting approaches—like prominently featuring existing health options and launching health-focused brand campaigns can amplify its effectiveness. By showcasing health-centric items with dedicated sections and transparent nutritional labeling, McDonald's can draw attention to its more nutritious offerings. This not only complements the customization strategy but also reassures health-conscious consumers of McDonald's commitment to wellness.

It's essential to address the challenges these strategies may encounter, such as operational complexities, cost implications, and potential perceptions of superficiality. The strategy will not require substantial adjustments to kitchen workflows, inventory systems, and staff training. McDonald's robust infrastructure and supply chain are well-equipped to handle these changes. To prevent health-oriented campaigns from being perceived as insincere, McDonald's must align marketing initiatives with real progress in its menu and operations, ensuring a credible and impactful repositioning.

Looking to the future, McDonald's ability to harmonize tradition and innovation will be crucial for maintaining its relevance in an increasingly competitive and health-conscious market. By adopting customization and outlining healthy options as the cornerstone of its strategy,

McDonald's can redefine its legacy while staying true to its mission of providing accessible, affordable, and enjoyable dining experiences. This comprehensive approach will not only solidify McDonald's position as a market leader but also set the stage for sustained growth and resilience in an ever-evolving industry.

In summary, McDonald's has a stellar opportunity to influence the future of fast food by embedding health-conscious values into its brand identity while preserving the qualities that have made it a global icon. By executing this strategy thoughtfully and committing to innovation, McDonald's can redefine fast food as both indulgent and health-focused, ensuring it resonates with diverse and dynamic consumers around the globe. With a precise strategy in place, McDonald's will surely reposition itself as the go-to fast-food option for healthy options, furthering their market share domination.

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